

Hyde Park, Built and Rebuilt

Production plan, script, and shot list

A HISTORY OF THE GROUND BENEATH A CHICAGO NEIGHBORHOOD . ROOTED FORWARD

An immersive documentary for rooted-forward.org. Seven chapters carry Hyde Park from Paul Cornell's 1853 lakefront bet through the University of Chicago, the 1893 World's Fair, the racial covenants, university-led urban renewal, and the present-day Obama Center. The cut already plays end to end with labeled placeholders, so you can watch it before filming anything.

How this works

The archival photographs in the cut are real, public-domain or Creative Commons images, and they stay. The narration you hear now is a scratch machine voice. You re-record every voiceover below in your own voice, then film the host pieces, the 360 look-arounds, and the present-day b-roll and swap them in for the placeholders. Upload a clip in /admin/studio or /admin/immersive and point the matching id at it; the cut updates in place.

Everything you film, in one place

YOUR TWO PIECES TO CAMERA

- **host-intro** Chapter 01 opening, on a Hyde Park sidewalk
- **host-close** Chapter 07 close, in Jackson Park by the Obama Center

360 CAPTURES WITH YOUR 3D CAMERA

- **pano-hyde-park** 57th Street Beach, facing the skyline across the lakefront
- **pano-main-quad** The center of the University of Chicago Main Quadrangles
- **pano-jackson-park** Jackson Park, by the Museum of Science and Industry and the Wooded Island
- **pano-55th-street** 55th Street, or the University Park townhouses, the rebuilt ground
- **pano-obama-center** The Obama Presidential Center site in Jackson Park

PRESENT-DAY B-ROLL

- **present-intro** Chapter 01
- **present-formation** Chapter 02

- **present-present** Chapter 07

The chapters

CHAPTER 01 . TODAY

Hyde Park, Ground That Keeps Moving

SAY THIS ON CAMERA

I'm standing in Hyde Park, on the South Side, about seven miles south of downtown. Look at these greystones. They feel like they were here before anybody, and like they'll outlast all of us. But this block looks the way it does because powerful institutions kept deciding it should, and plenty of people got moved so it could happen. This is some of the most reshaped ground in Chicago, and the people doing the reshaping had money and a plan, and almost none of them lived here. So here is the question I want us to carry the whole way through. Who keeps deciding what this neighborhood becomes, and what happens to the people already here when they do.

RECORD THIS VOICEOVER

Hyde Park sits about seven miles south of downtown Chicago, along the shore of Lake Michigan. At first glance, it feels timeless. The greystones, tree-lined streets, and Gothic buildings look as though they've always belonged here. But almost every part of this neighborhood exists because someone with money and influence decided it should. Over the past 170 years, Hyde Park has been built, demolished, and rebuilt over and over again. Railroads, universities, and government agencies reshaped the landscape, while the people who already lived here often had little say in what happened next. It started with a railroad crossing open prairie, followed by a university and a World's Fair. Then, in the 1950s, federal urban renewal displaced more than 15,000 residents. The neighborhood has never really stopped changing.

SHOTS AND DIRECTION

Present-day handheld opener with the host on a Hyde Park sidewalk, lakefront and stone two-flats in frame. B-roll of older greystone houses, the University of Chicago Gothic quad, and the Olmsted parkland along the lake. Establishing wide of the neighborhood from a high vantage to sell the seven-miles-south-of-the-Loop geography. A 360 capture in Jackson Park near the Obama Presidential Center campus to set up the present-day foreshadow, framed so the same parkland that held the 1893 fair is visible. Talking-head beat for the host close-out question, framed medium, warm daylight. Hold a slow push on a quiet residential block for the line about people living on the ground.

Paul Cornell's Lakefront Bet

RECORD THIS VOICEOVER

In 1853 a young lawyer named Paul Cornell bought three hundred acres of lakefront and named it Hyde Park, after the one in London. The land was useless if you couldn't get there. So Cornell handed the Illinois Central Railroad sixty acres, and the railroad gave him a station at 53rd Street and six trains a day downtown. Prairie turned into suburb. In 1857 he put up a four-story wood hotel by the water, the Hyde Park House. Mary Todd Lincoln stayed there in 1865 with her sons Robert and Tad, a few months after her husband was killed. Within ten years a thousand people lived here. The township held 15,716 people in 1880. By 1889 it held about eighty-five thousand, and that year the voters chose to join Chicago for the water and the sewers. From the start, Cornell sold the place as selective, a retreat for people with means, a clean distance from the city's crowds.

SHOTS AND DIRECTION

Open on present-day lakefront at 53rd Street and Lake Michigan, where the Hyde Park House once stood, slow push toward the water. Capture the Metra Electric (former Illinois Central) tracks and the 53rd Street/Hyde Park station platform as a living trace of Cornell's 1853 railroad deal. 360 capture along the lakefront path between 51st and 55th to convey the original 300-acre tract. Period maps or archival photos of the four-story Hyde Park House and an 1880s township boundary map as overlays (39th to 138th, State Street to the lake). B-roll of Oak Woods Cemetery for Cornell's grave. No talking-head needed for this history chapter; let footage and archival stills carry it.

ARCHIVAL STILLS ALREADY IN THE CUT

- Paul Cornell (1822-1904) Public domain . TonyTheTiger at en.wikipedia
- Mary Todd Lincoln restored Public domain . Nicolas H. Shepherd, photographer.Jebulon for restoration and upload
- 1857 Bird's Eye View of Chicago - LOC Public domain . Lithograph by Christian Inger, based on a drawing by I. T. Palmatary. Published by Braunhold & Sonne
- Hyde Park House Public domain . The original uploader was TonyTheTiger at English Wikipedia
- Great Central Station trainshed Public domain . Leslie's Illustrated Newspaper

Rockefeller's University Rises

RECORD THIS VOICEOVER

The campus started with one man's money. In 1889, John D. Rockefeller pledged six hundred thousand dollars for a new Baptist university in Chicago. He set one condition. Other donors had to match four hundred thousand more, and they did. The school incorporated in 1890. Marshall Field, the department store man, gave the first ten acres in Hyde Park. Rockefeller picked William Rainey Harper to run it, a Yale doctorate he had earned in his teens. Harper built a research university from nothing. Classes opened in 1892 with five hundred ninety-four men and women. Henry Ives Cobb laid out the gray Gothic quads you still walk through. The same institution that built them would later decide who got to live around them.

SHOTS AND DIRECTION

Film present-day Hyde Park main quadrangles in the gray limestone Gothic, with corbels, crenellations, gargoyles, and grotesques in frame. Capture Cobb Lecture Hall exterior (the first building completed, ready for the October 1892 opening). 360 capture from the center of the main quad looking across the interlocking quadrangles toward the towers. Slow walking shots along the cloistered walks to evoke the Oxford and Cambridge model. B-roll of period-style markers or plaques naming Harper, Field, and the founding dates if visible on campus. Optional archival-style stills under the host of Rockefeller, Harper, Marshall Field, and Henry Ives Cobb's campus plan. A separate establishing shot toward the lakefront ties the campus to the 1893 Exposition site nearby. Keep any generated or test imagery labeled.

ARCHIVAL STILLS ALREADY IN THE CUT

- Cobb Hall of the University of Chicago, Illinois (65900) Public domain . Tichnor Brothers, Publisher
- William Rainey Harper, 1856-1906, bust portrait LCCN2005691332 Public domain . Miscellaneous Items in High Demand, PPOC, Library of Congress
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- Americana 1920 Libraries - University of Chicago Harper Memorial Library Public domain . Unknown photographer
- Marshall Field illustration 1893 Public domain . unknown for Chicago Inter Ocean

The White City in Jackson Park

RECORD THIS VOICEOVER

For six months in 1893, Jackson Park wasn't a park. It was a fair. The World's Columbian Exposition opened May 1 and ran to October 30, built to mark four hundred years since Columbus reached the Americas. Daniel Burnham ran the construction. Frederick Law Olmsted, who'd helped design Central Park, turned the marshy lakefront into lagoons. At the center stood the Court of Honor, white plaster halls, lit up at night by electricity. People called it the White City. About twenty-seven million came. Almost none of it was built to last. The Palace of Fine Arts was the exception. It reopened in 1933 as the Museum of Science and Industry. The fair made this lakefront valuable ground. The fight over who it belonged to was still ahead.

SHOTS AND DIRECTION

Present-day Jackson Park footage. Slow approach on the Museum of Science and Industry exterior (the former Palace of Fine Arts) showing the limestone facade and classical columns. Walk the lagoon edge toward Olmsted's Wooded Island, drone or 360 capture over the lagoon and bridges. Capture the open lawns where the Court of Honor once stood. Intercut archival images of the 1893 White City and the original Ferris Wheel if cleared for use. For the Midway Plaisance, a tracking shot down the mile-long green strip from Jackson Park toward Washington Park. Optional talking-head beat from a local historian standing near the MSI entrance noting that this single brick-substructure building is what outlasted the fair.

ARCHIVAL STILLs ALREADY IN THE CUT

- The Court Of Honor — Official Views Of The World's Columbian Exposition — 15 Public domain . C. D. Arnold (1844-1927); H. D. Higinbotham
- Palace Of Fine Arts — Official Views Of The World's Columbian Exposition — 59 Public domain . C. D. Arnold (1844-1927); H. D. Higinbotham
- Agricultural Building — Official Views Of The World's Columbian Exposition — 18 Public domain . C. D. Arnold (1844-1927); H. D. Higinbotham
- The Ferris Wheel — Official Views Of The World's Columbian Exposition — 91 Public domain . C. D. Arnold (1844-1927); H. D. Higinbotham
- The Midway, Looking West — Official Views Of The World's Columbian Exposition — 97 Public domain . C. D. Arnold (1844-1927); H. D. Higinbotham

The Color Line Comes to Hyde Park

RECORD THIS VOICEOVER

*At 6140 South Rhodes Avenue in Woodlawn, one line in the deed barred selling or renting to anyone who wasn't white. They called it a racially restrictive covenant. Neighbors signed in blocs, so the clause covered the whole block. Hyde Park and Woodlawn leaned on these covenants. And the University of Chicago was not a bystander. It put money behind defending them in court, to keep the blocks around its campus white. Black Chicago kept growing the whole time. About 40,000 people in 1910, around 278,000 by 1940, most of them held inside a thin strip of the South Side. Not until 1948 did the Supreme Court take their force away, in *Shelley v. Kraemer*. The clauses stayed in the deeds. Courts just couldn't enforce them anymore.*

SHOTS AND DIRECTION

Open on present-day Hyde Park and Kenwood residential streets, slow tracking past brick three-flats and graystones that would have carried covenant clauses. Capture a 360 node at a Woodlawn corner near 6140 South Rhodes Avenue (Washington Park subdivision), exterior only, to anchor the Hansberry case. Film the University of Chicago campus edge where it meets the surrounding neighborhoods to underscore the institutional role. B-roll suggestions: archival-style inserts of a deed page and Great Migration rail imagery if licensed, otherwise hold on present-day storefronts and the 53rd Street corridor. No talking-head beat for this history chapter; narration carries it. End on a quiet exterior of a Kenwood block to hand off to the urban renewal chapter.

ARCHIVAL STILLS ALREADY IN THE CUT

- African-American-family-South-Chicago-1922 CC BY 4.0 . Schomburg Center for Research in Black Culture, Jean Blackwell Hutson Research and Reference Division, The New York Public Library (1168439)
- Home Owners' Loan Corp. (HOLC) Neighborhood Redlining Grade in Chicago, Illinois CC BY-SA 4.0 . Joelean Hall
- Lorraine Hansberry House CC BY-SA 4.0 . Legimet
- Chicagoblackbelt Public domain . Russell Lee
- Scott Arthur Family 1920 Public domain . The Chicago Defender; Chicago Commission on Race Relations
- Washday of family on relief. Chicago, Illinois LCCN2017788876 Public domain . Russell Lee

The University Rebuilds the Neighborhood

RECORD THIS VOICEOVER

In 1952 the University of Chicago set up the South East Chicago Commission to remake the blocks around its campus. Chancellor Lawrence Kimpton chaired it, and a lawyer named Julian Levi ran it day to day. The plan they backed covered eight hundred fifty-six acres. It marked six hundred thirty-eight buildings to come down. The first one fell on May tenth, 1955, before the plan was even approved. The City Council made it official in 1958. All told, the plan would push out about four thousand families. The university spent twenty-nine million dollars of its own money to buy the land and rebuild it. The people who came back weren't a random slice. In those first projects, forty-six percent of the white families who lost homes stayed in Hyde Park. Among Black families, it was seventeen. Across the renewal, the neighborhood's Black population fell by about forty percent. Then the university looked south, toward Woodlawn.

SHOTS AND DIRECTION

Present-day Hyde Park between 55th and the Midway. Film the rebuilt blocks of Hyde Park A and B around 55th Street and Lake Park, the townhouse and tower complexes that replaced the cleared buildings, for direct before-and-after contrast. Capture the University of Chicago campus edge and the South East Chicago Commission context near 55th and University. 360 capture along 55th Street looking east-west to show the scale of the cleared corridor. Drive or walk south toward 61st Street and Woodlawn to set up the closing beat. Archival overlays of demolition photos if licensed. Optional talking-head with a Hyde Park or Woodlawn historian on who relocated within the neighborhood and who did not.

ARCHIVAL STILLs ALREADY IN THE CUT

- Aerial View of Chicago, Hyde Park, Chicago Beach, 1928 (NBY 5351) Public domain . Chicago Aerial Survey
- University Apartments (7375178340) cropped CC BY-SA 4.0 . Teemu008 from Palatine, Illinois
- 55th Street, Hyde Park, Chicago, IL (54825433377) CC BY-SA 4.0 . Warren LeMay from Chicago, IL, United States

Hyde Park Now

SAY THIS ON CAMERA

I'm standing in Jackson Park, and behind me is the Obama Presidential Center. People waited more than a decade for this to become reality, and for many, it's a major investment in the South Side. But there's another side of the story that didn't make it into the ribbon-cutting. As the Center was being built, Woodlawn, the neighborhood that worked for years to bring it here, became far more expensive. On the blocks closest to the project, home prices doubled. So I keep coming back to one question. When investment transforms a neighborhood, who gets to stay and be part of what they helped create?

RECORD THIS VOICEOVER

The Obama Presidential Center opened on June 19, 2026. Juneteenth. The museum tower runs about two hundred twenty-five feet over Jackson Park. Olmsted and Vaux laid out this park in 1871, and it's the same ground that held the 1893 World's Fair. The campus cost about eight hundred fifty million dollars. No presidential center has ever cost more. Getting it built took years. The site was picked in 2016. A group called Protect Our Parks sued over and over to stop it. Every suit failed. Construction started in 2021. And while the Center went up, Woodlawn got more expensive. On the blocks closest to it, home prices doubled after 2019. By 2024, less than a third of the housing nearby was still affordable.

SHOTS AND DIRECTION

Present-day exteriors of the Obama Presidential Center museum tower from multiple angles in Jackson Park, including a low upward shot to convey the ~225-foot height. Wide lakefront establishing shot showing the campus against Lake Michigan. 360 capture from the park lawn near the tower base for the immersive viewer. Host talking-head walk-and-talk on a Jackson Park path with the Center visible over the shoulder. B-roll along East Woodlawn residential streets (single-family blocks nearest the Center) showing newer renovations beside older housing; no recognizable faces without release. Optional archival still of the 1893 World's Columbian Exposition for the historic overlay. Capture exterior signage and the public entrance for the opening-date callout.

What the film already does

This is not a storyboard on paper. The cut is rendered and runs about six and a half minutes. Built into it:

- **A warm-duotone archival look.** Every historical photo is graded to a consistent sepia and shown complete over a blurred copy of itself, so faces and buildings are never cropped.
- **An animated locator map and master timeline.** A stylized South Side map shows Washington Park and Jackson Park framing Hyde Park, and a 1853-to-today timeline runs as a hero sequence and as a lit ribbon that carries across every chapter.
- **Two verified data charts.** The renewal return-rate gap as paired bars, 46 percent of white families stayed versus 17 percent of Black families, and the Black population growth from about 40,000 in 1910 to about 278,000 by 1940 as an animated census curve.
- **Museum wall labels.** Fifteen labels emerge on the beat the narration names a subject, the Ferris Wheel, the Court of Honor, Rockefeller, the Hansberry House, each pointing at a confirmed detail.
- **Dimensional stat moments.** The hero numbers, 300 acres, 594 students, about 4,000 families, are extruded into depth and count up, then hold.
- **Disciplined motion.** Each shot makes one slow move and settles, sized to read on a large wall.

Ground rules the film keeps

- Real, verified facts only. No invented numbers, quotes, dates, or sources.
- Every image is genuinely public domain or Creative Commons, credited on screen and in the sources.
- No em-dashes and no colons inside sentences in any on-screen text, the most reliable AI tells.

Verified sources

Pulled from the fact-check pass. Each chapter's claims were checked against these.

HYDE PARK, GROUND THAT KEEPS MOVING

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HYDE PARK NOW

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